

Safety Fitness Determination · how it works

For Acme Trucking LLC

The Safety Fitness Determination (SFD) is the FMCSA's formal rating of your carrier's overall safety. There are three: Satisfactory, Conditional, Unsatisfactory. The rating drives insurance, freight tendering, and (at Unsatisfactory) shutdown.

I · THE THREE RATINGS · §385.5

RATING	WHAT IT MEANS	OPERATIONAL IMPACT
Satisfactory	Sufficient safety management controls in place	Full operating authority · normal insurance · normal freight
Conditional	Some controls missing or deficient · safety violations identified	Operating authority continues · insurance rates jump · shippers + brokers see the rating · freight may dry up
Unsatisfactory	Multiple severe deficiencies · public safety risk	Operating authority revoked within 45-60 days (HM in 45) unless corrected · most carriers shut down
Unrated	New entrants (first 18 months) + no review yet	Normal authority · pending the New Entrant audit

II · HOW A RATING GETS ISSUED · §385.13

FMCSA issues a safety rating after a Compliance Review (CR), which is a deeper audit than a New Entrant audit. CRs are triggered by:

- Two or more alerted BASICs on your SMS profile
- A fatal accident or pattern of serious crashes
- A complaint or whistleblower report
- Random selection
- Failed New Entrant audit

III · THE 6 FACTORS INVESTIGATORS EVALUATE · §385.7

1. **Adequacy of safety management controls** · do you have written policies, supervisor training, audit procedures
2. **Frequency + severity of regulatory violations** · roadside, audit, accident-related
3. **Frequency + severity of CMV accidents** · the Crash Indicator BASIC + the accidents themselves
4. **Acute + critical violations found during the review** · 16 acute = auto-conditional / unsatisfactory
5. **Past patterns of violations** · whether issues have been corrected
6. **Operating practices in the BASICS** · Driver Fitness, HOS, Vehicle Maintenance, etc.

IV · IF YOU GET A CONDITIONAL OR UNSATISFACTORY · WHAT TO DO

1. **Read the rating letter** · it lists specific deficiencies + the regulatory cites
2. **Request a Safety Audit (SA)** or Corrective Action Plan (CAP) acceptance within 60 days · §385.17
3. **Build the CAP** · for each cited deficiency · what changed, who owns it, when it was implemented, what evidence proves it
4. **Submit the CAP to FMCSA** · they accept or reject · accepted means you get a follow-up review chance
5. **For Unsatisfactory** · file a petition for administrative review or §385.15 · while doing so, fix everything that's fixable · 45 days for HM, 60 for general freight · then operating authority is revoked
6. **If revoked** · you can re-apply for operating authority after demonstrating you've fixed the issues · but it takes 6-18 months

The SFD is the single most important number in your carrier's life. Insurance underwriters look at it before they price. Brokers look at it before they tender. Shippers look at it before they list you. A Conditional rating cuts revenue access by 20-50%; Unsatisfactory ends the business.